

Advocacy Reflective Summary

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When I began my coursework, I thought of advocacy mainly as speaking up for someone who could not speak for themselves. My work in this area helped me understand that advocacy is much broader and should begin with listening, learning, and recognizing the barriers that keep people from receiving support. Researching autism spectrum disorder showed me how communication differences, social challenges, limited resources, and unequal access to services can affect children and their families. I also learned that autism occurs across racial, ethnic, and socioeconomic groups, yet families do not always have the same opportunities to obtain early treatment. This helped me move beyond simply feeling concern and begin thinking more carefully about access, equity, and the responsibility counselors have to respond.

Creating the advocacy assignment, fact sheet, awareness materials, community flyer, and workshop resources taught me how to turn information into something useful. I learned that research has greater value when it can be communicated clearly to families, schools, and community members. These projects encouraged me to think about the audience, the language I use, and whether a resource is practical and approachable. I began to see that counselors can advocate in many ways, including sharing reliable resources, providing school workshops, participating in awareness campaigns, and helping clients develop self-advocacy skills. I also became more aware that effective advocacy should build on people's strengths instead of defining them only by their needs or challenges.

Throughout this coursework, I have grown from viewing advocacy as an additional counseling role to seeing it as part of ethical and responsive practice. I now understand that supporting a client inside a counseling session may not be enough when outside barriers continue to affect their well-being. As a future counselor, I want to remain curious about what families need, connect them with appropriate resources, and use my position to make information and services easier to access. I also want to be careful not to assume that I know what is best for a community without listening to its members. This work has strengthened my commitment to being a counselor who not only offers empathy, but also takes thoughtful action alongside clients and communities.